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Issue #50
mar 7 - mar 13

<https://stacker.news/items/50>

43 sats \ 2 replies \ @k00b 16 Jun 2021 \ on:
Next Bitcoin Soft-Fork ANYPREVOUT bitcoin
afaict there isn't a ton of consensus around
this being the soft fork yet

<https://stacker.news/items/5050>

2 sats \ 1 reply \ @User21952 OP 16 Nov 2021 \
on: Bitcoin Company Synonym Launches
Architecture For A Self-Sovereign Economy
bitcoin

"You simply do not need a blockchain to create
what they call 'Web3' user experiences and
designs. We are solving the same problems
using Slashtags and Hypercore to establish a
new social economy web paradigm without
the nonsense of unscalable blockchain
bullshit," he said. "The Web3 and Metaverse
narrative will haunt us for years, and require
much re-education to separate design ideas
from the people simply trying to pump their
investments to greater fools."

John Carvalho, CEO of Synonym

<https://stacker.news/items/505050>

7 sats \ 0 replies \ @Bell_curve 13 Apr 2024 \
parent \ on: The Anti-Fragile Brendan Eich |
Andrew Beck BooksAndArticles

Cancel culture is now a Frankenstein

Note from the Editor

what they said ^

50

zines?! whoa!!

by @plebpoet

with @k00b

builder boost

invitation to munkfest: the new freedom territory



15.4k sats \ 2 comments \
@PSYFER 11 Mar events art
bitcoin nostr culture



You are toxically
invited to the final
festival at the UK's
largest underground
Bitcoin Hub.

MUNKFEST 26

CYPHERMUNK HOUSE
21-22 MARCH, LONDON
SUPPORTED BY
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and Yakihonne

Fellow Stackers, we have been running Bitcoin events from
our London base for the last two years and have been
kindly described as;

"The most impressive physical Bitcoin embassy." Avi Burra
"The most important cultural venue in the UK Bitcoin
space." Rebel Money
and
"Cypherpunk as fuck!" Max Hillebrand

In ten days time we host MUNKFEST 26, our final festival at
our current home following Be Your Bank '24 and Bloom
Fest '25. And the schedule has just dropped.

With talks on Bitcoin, anarchy, time and ketosis, plus
workshops on SeedSigner, Linux and self-hosted AI from
some of the UK and Europe's smartest devs, educators and
creatives, this is your last chance to experience the
madness of the Munkhouse. ...

MUNKFEST 26
CYPHERMUNK
HOUSE
21 & 22
MARCH,
LONDON
Tickets,
Schedule and
Lineup [HERE](#)





blog: ~ do ya like art? ~ no.1 intro

8311 sats \ 18 comments \ @plebpoet 7 Mar art
the_stack_muse BooksAndArticles



Do you like art? Do I like art?

After plaguing myself with doubt and insecurity for many years, I've actually become an artist. Hooray!

Of course, I'm not the kind of artist that I once idolized, sure. I haven't made my biggest dream happen, yet. Nonetheless, I spend a good portion of my time producing my ideas into tiny soldiers that move out into the world to do whatever they have to do. I make art and I earn something for it. In simple terms, *that's an artist*.

But, do I like art? There's a discussion to be had.

This will be a series where I discuss my musings on the art I see in the world, the value of art I hold as an ideal, and the progress I'm making in my own work. It may also become the space for me to vent my discontent with artificial intelligence, who knows?

the catalyst

This week will bring the first session of an art class I've enrolled in: a real in-person art class to learn the skill of screen printing. I'm very excited. I haven't taken a formal art class before. I've been educated in literature, but everything else I do is coming from a desire to create and someone else on the internet doing it first.

I thought I might take you along with me as I take on this class. And I'm taking a page out of @TotallyHumanWriter's book with his **Unfiltered** series. I'll try filling the void he has left behind with the conclusion of these thoughtful pieces.

I'm coming into this with some derogatory fuel against the institution of art as it showcased for us in prized exhibitions for public viewing. I went to the art museum last night. I found out that the same organization who outfits the class I'll be taking also holds up the function of the art museum I often pass on the street, and this weekend, the newest show opened. So I thought, *hey, why not? It'll be fun to get in the building and maybe I'll even meet someone doing the same class, I don't know, what the hell?*

Turns out, this was a profound waste of time, even unsettling. Two things happened at the start which tinted the evening toward ruin. Checking in with the staff at the desk, I tried one single line of pleasantry. The way this man looked at me in response was to remind me that he was *not* my barista. Okay. We move on. Then I began to take in the artist's work in the short paragraph presented at the entrance, filling in detail on the exhibit, the artist, and who sponsored the prize they won. From the first sentence, I knew I was going to need to neutralize the expression on my face.

I can easily sum up the contents of this exhibit: enlarged coloring book pages, the same tiny photograph 5 times, words on the wall in neon light, playground-like structures of aluminum.

It may not be fair for me to give a critique of this artist, since I was moved to a snap decision about it based off of a few words, so I won't. I'll critique the vibe of the event: it was discomfort. Perhaps because I was alone and didn't know anyone, perhaps because the art was condescending -- oh shoot, I wasn't going to be critical of that. I tried to find one thing I liked about it, any of it, and you know what it was? The stairwell. Someone put googly eyes on a pipe and I thought *that's more like it*. It was the one hallowed space where I felt I was a person again. Even my brief excursion to the restroom (simply to disappear from the crowd for a moment) was intolerable given the close proximity to the company who moved through it.

I'm not sure I can say what it was exactly. I do a variety of things on my own, this is not out of character for me. Given that, I don't think I can attribute my discomfort to that source. I just think these art people were icky. Genuinely^[1]. I haven't felt so deeply out of place since I was a teenager.

I'll propose a reason for this. I think art at that level, or at that scale, isn't concerned with anything in common with me and what I'm concerned with. I think it is spectacle. I think it is means-to-an-end. Or scratch that, maybe it's actually *kayfabe*. Maybe it's sophisticated porn. It wears self-obsession like a cologne so expensive you couldn't possibly discern a single whiff of it. The character Ellsworth Toohey who Ayn Rand created in *The Fountainhead*, this would have been his party, for sure.

So I ask myself, do I even like art?

If it's hung in a museum and it's less than 100 years old, maybe not?

If it isn't asked to engage with people, if it isn't bringing something new to our attention, if it isn't....so what is it?

More on this later 🙌

1. There was one guy standing around who was not utterly put together, but was wearing a printed button up opened over an Aphex Twin tee I recognized. Had to mention him, he was the one guy out of the sea of people who I thought, yeah I could talk to him. ☺



the other bitcoin mystery: where's friedcat?

29.4k sats \ 37 comments \ @siggy47 9 Mar
bitcoin bitcoin_Mining BooksAndArticles



I recently bought a bunch of ASICMiner Block Erupter USB miners on Ebay. They are really just collector's items at this point, since mining technology passed them by years ago. I did start researching the company, which is how I came across the Friedcat mystery. I spent more time researching this crazy story than a sane person should, so I figured I would document what I discovered:

Friedcat's Early Years

Friedcat (Jiang Xinyu) was born in 1986 in Shaoyang, Hunan Province, China. Very few details of his childhood are known, but reasonable assumptions can be made. Shaoyang was a working class region. It is unlikely that his childhood was wealthy. It is likely, however, that his parents were strongly interested and motivated towards getting him the best education possible. He had enough raw intellectual ability to gain admittance to the First Middle School of Shaoyang, Hunan, but he would probably also require coaching, exam preparation and strong academic nurturing to succeed as he did. The First Middle School of Shaoyang was the city's elite school, a feeder for top universities. According to the school's web site, the first principal was "Chairman Mao's teacher, Mr. Zhang Gan, a famous educator." Friedcat was an exceptional student. His name still appears on the permanent Honor Roll displayed on a wall near the front entrance. At graduation he was ranked 11th academically in Hunan Province. He was admitted to the [University Of Science & Technology Of China \(USTC\)](#) when he was 15 years old. This institution is considered one of the most competitive universities in the country.

Contrary to information found on some online articles, Friedcat never received a PhD. He was awarded a master's degree in computer science in 2009, when he would have been 23 or 24 years old. His thesis was entitled "Constructing Secure Thread Mechanisms Using Formal Methods."

He then entered the USTC-Yale High Confidence Software Research Center PhD program. ...



At USTC Friedcat met two people who would remain in his life post college - Wang Xian, his then girlfriend and future wife, and Fan Dawei, his future business partner. Friedcat introduced Fan Dawei to the Haskell programming language while they were students at USTC.

Friedcat and Fan Dawei's friendship grew when they both were members of the FLINT visiting scholar program at Yale University, in New Haven, Connecticut. They were the only two Chinese scholars in that program at the time. They co-authored a paper while at Yale:

"Proof-Carrying Compiler Code Optimization and Program Specification Conversion" (出具证明编译器中代码优化与程序规范转换). *Journal of Chinese Computer Systems* (小型微型计算机系统), Vol. 7, pp. 1400-1405.

Friedcat and Fan Dawei were roommates at Yale. It was during this time in the U.S. that Fan Dawei introduced Friedcat to bitcoin. Reading the white paper changed the trajectory of both their lives. There was no indication previously that Friedcat had strong political views. He was an academic preparing for life as a scholar within the Chinese system. Now, he began to be introduced to the anarchic, libertarian ideas of the Austrian school economists and Ayn Rand. Fan Dawei was quoted as saying "I was originally a mild-mannered centrist. He turned me into a complete anarchist." The two students would discuss politics and bitcoin in their off campus apartment in New Haven, frequenting the Chinese restaurants that catered to the large Chinese student population at Yale. Friends described Friedcat as a bit of an introvert, with a peaceful, non aggressive nature and a good sense of humor. Friedcat was a devoted carnivore. Enjoying restaurant meals seemed to be his main social activity.

Friedcat and Fan Dawei both dropped out of the visiting scholar program. Both had lost interest in their academic path, and their focus turned exclusively to bitcoin. They began to plan their mining business while still in the U.S.

They returned to China in early 2012, first stopping at the USTC campus to pack up their belongings, then moved to Shenzhen to start their bitcoin mining business. Friedcat created his Bitcointalk user name on January 16, 2012.

Shenzhen

The founders of the new company moved to the Fengye Pinyuan serviced apartment complex, Nanshan District, Shenzhen. located at South Mountain Ave & Binhai Ave intersection, near Shenzhen University and the high-tech park. The building where they lived is now called The Maple Leaf Kwaifa Apartment. It is listed for overnight stays on Tripadvisor. Friedcat shared a room with Zhuang Zhong, and Fan Dawei shared a room with Wang Song.

Shenzhen Skyline (2012)



Shenzhen was already being described in 2012 as China's Silicon Valley. It was a city of migrants. It embodied the "shanzhai" culture. Shanzhai literally means "mountain fortress" and originally referred to bandit strongholds - by extension, counterfeit or imitation products. →

It was a culture of copying existing products cheaply. Friedcat and his co-workers could develop their mining products, then quickly and easily have them manufactured. This was crucial in the competitive early days of bitcoin mining, and Friedcat exploited this advantage. Fan Dawei registered Bitfountain, the operational company behind ASICMiner, in Shenzhen on July 12, 2012. It was agreed that Fan Dawei would be responsible for managing internal product design, while Friedcat would handle investor relations. Bitfountain and ASICMiner never had a website. All Friedcat's investor and customer relations were done through Bitcointalk. These threads are still all accessible. Zhuang Zhong was responsible for software and coding. Wang Song handled operations, procurement, supply chain, and mining farm management. He managed the Shenzhen and Huai'an farms.

ASICMiner began listing on the Global Bitcoin Stock Exchange (GLBSE) on August 7, 2012. It has been suggested that this was the first ICO in history. The total shares issued were 400,000, at a price of 0.1 BTC per share. Bitfountain held 236,038 shares (59%), and the public float was 163,962 shares, or 41 %. The total capital raised was about \$150,000. 100% of the profit was to be distributed to shareholders, weekly, on Wednesdays.

Both Wu Jihan and Xie Jian invested 1,000 BTC at the IPO, and each received 10,000 shares and 2,500 bonus shares. Both of these people will become relevant as the story unfolds.

The Early Days of Bitcoin Mining

It makes sense to look at Bitfountain's offering in the context of the bitcoin mining ecosystem in 2012. During this period, CPU and GPU mining were obsolete, and field programmable gate array (FPGA) mining was being explored. It was the beginning of the ASIC era.

Butterfly Labs was the first company to publicly announce their ASIC technology, in June of 2012. The other four companies in the race were Avalon/Canaan, bASIC, and Bitfountain's ASICMiner. Bitfountain had a different business plan than the others. They intended to develop the chip to mine internally, and sell shares to investors. The other companies intended to market ASIC machines. Avalon shipped ASICs first, but Friedcat started mining first.

On December 28, 2012, the company posted photos of its chip carrier – the first ASIC miner – on Bitcointalk. By January 31, 2013, ASICMiner had 64-chip boards and aimed to deploy 800 of them, mounted in 10-board backplanes. By February 14, it had 2 TH/s miners operating.

Friedcat's strategy was very successful at the beginning. At one point in early 2013 ASICMiner had 42% of the entire bitcoin network's hash rate. Friedcat became aware of the growing concerns expressed on Bitcointalk about his high hash rate and the possibility of a 51% attack, so he began to voluntarily shed hash rate to keep it below 20%.



ASICMiner Block Erupter USB

ASICMiner also began selling the Block Erupter USB on Bitcointalk. These small devices had 330MH/s, and cost about \$13 each. You can still buy them on Ebay as collector's items. At the time they served to democratize bitcoin mining, making it easy for just about every stacker to participate. Reading about the Block Erupters reminded me of today's solo miners.

Wu Jihan is rebuffed and starts Bitmain

Wu Jihan had done well financially investing with Friedcat. Although the timing is unclear, at some point he asked Fan Dawei to join Bitfountain. He was a financial professional with investment experience at the time, and his credentials were impeccable. He also was a strong believer in bitcoin. Besides Bitmain, he may be best known for having translated the white paper into Chinese. His translation is still the one most widely used today. There is little explanation as to why Fan Dawei refused Wu's offer to join the team, but as a result Wu started his own mining manufacturing company, Bitmain. Friedcat was not involved in the decision. The rest, as they say, is history. Ultimately Bitmain grew to dominate the space as a competitor of ASICMiner.

Friedcat and ASICMiner thrived in 2013. For an introvert, it seems a bit strange that he was head of investor relations, but all customer contact and marketing was done online on the Bitcointalk forum. His friends described him as unkempt and not very talkative. He would never appear publicly at meetups or conferences. Friedcat very much embodied the cypherpunk anarchist stereotype. One friend said Fried dreamed of one day living on a remote island with like minded people outside the reach of any government.

Friedcat was well liked, respected, and trusted on the forums. He was known for his catch phrase – "Don't Panic." He grew wealthy quickly, and those who invested with him did well too. Dividends were paid weekly.



The Decline And Fall
The Decline And Fall
The Decline And Fall
The Decline And Fall



Keep reading the saga online! where will it end? will the mystery be revealed?

top meme

302 sats \ 0 replies \ @purpurato 9 Mar



"Fear not, my lady, I am registering to vote it out."

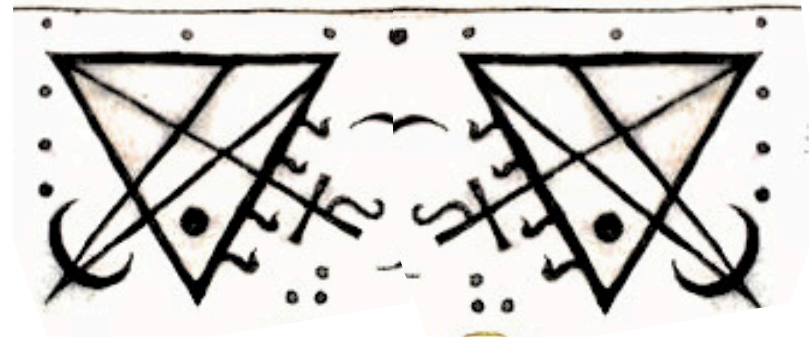


155 sats \ 0 replies \ @OneOneSeven 9 Mar



You're concealing an attached wallet, are you not?

You're concealing a horse to receive sats, aren't you?



top post

from cash to crypto: towards
a consistent regulatory
approach to illicit payment



7108 sats \ 20 comments \ @Scoresby 9 Mar Politics_And_Law

tl;dr - self custody is so important. It still poses lots of challenges to the surveillance state even though they are trying to lock it down.

These bastards can write something like this:

- *legitimate actors may also change their choice of payment instrument to the least intermediated and monitored option if they have concerns about their privacy or doubts about their privacy or doubts about their intermediaries' ability and willingness to protect their payments data.*

And still act like self custody is a problem.

They've built a system that only works because of intermediaries

- *implementation of AML/CFT measures generally relies on the existence of trusted intermediaries, or "obliged entities", that intermediate in transactions on behalf of their customers and act as gatekeepers. In this intermediary role, these entities are in a unique position to screen customers, monitor transactions and report suspicious transactions to financial intelligence units.*

Is it really so hard for them to imagine that perfectly normal people don't like being treated like criminals?

Complaining about how difficult it is to track cash payments, they say:

- *the physical nature of cash is likely to impose, by design, practical limitations on its usefulness for illicit purposes, which may cap the associated societal costs. Physical cash is often cumbersome and less portable than digital forms of money, making it impractical for large transactions, risky to store and transport, and time-consuming.*

It's news to me that cash was designed to place limits on its usefulness.

• Hence, we hypothesise that, in the absence of additional or alternative AML/CFT measures, self-hosted crypto payments present the lowest probability of detection and enforcement after cash.

Yes.

They acknowledge that people don't like others snooping on them and that the AML/CFT regime is an imposition on everybody. But they justify it as a "public good."

• to address this trade-off, AML/CFT frameworks are generally implemented alongside strong data privacy measures.

This is laughable. To call any data privacy measures "strong" in the era of frequent billion-record hacks and leaks is stupid.

They describe very nicely how the scope of financial surveillance has only expanded (and dramatically so) since the 1990s. ...

EU regulatory framework for AML and CFT: evolution and key changes

Graph 2

1991 Council Directive 91/308/EEC "AMLD1"	•Definition of key AML principles: •Client identification. •Transaction monitoring and record-keeping. •Reporting of suspicious transactions.	
2001 Directive 2001/97/EC "AMLD2"	•Expansion of obliged entities beyond credit and financial institutions.	
2005 Directive 2005/60/EC "AMLD3"	•Extension of goal of AML framework to include CFT. •Formalisation of risk-based approach as principle for rules and checks. •Replacement of client identification with CDD obligation.	
2015 Directive (EU) 2015/849 "AMLD4"	•Increased emphasis on risk-based approach for AML rules and checks. •Definition of more prescriptive approach to transaction monitoring. •Strengthening of CDD obligations.	
2018 Directive (EU) 2018/843 "AMLD5"	•Expansion of list of obliged entities with crypto exchanges and custodian wallet providers.	
2023 Regulation (EU) 2023/113 "Travel Rule" (First building block of AML package)	•Expansion of application of legislation on information accompanying funds transfers to transfers of virtual assets. •Replacement of notion of "virtual currency" with "cryptoasset".	
2023 Proposal COM (2023) 369 final "DigEuro-Reg"	•Expansion of scope of existing AML regulation to digital euro payments. •Distinction of exact treatment depending on definition and form of digital euro payments.	
2024 •Regulation (EU) 2024/1624 "AMLR" •Regulation (EU) 2024/1620 "AMLAR" •Directive (EU) 2024/1640 "AMLD6" (Remaining building blocks of AML package)	•Embedding of AML requirements in directly applicable legal act. •Creation of EU-wide authority for the application and enforcement of AML rules. •Introduction of EU-wide cash payment limit. •Introduction of new sanctions compliance obligations, ad hoc measures for cryptoassets and new CDD.	

Note: AML = anti-money laundering; CDD = customer due diligence; CFT = combating the financing of terrorism; KYC = know-your-customer.

Source: Authors' elaborations.

All in all, this is a very frustrating read. I find it hard to believe that there are people who seriously buy in to the nanny state so deeply that they dismiss the risks of such state control so lightly.

source

sn release: what you see is what you get (wysiwyg) editor



4369 sats \ 53 comments \ @k00b 11 Mar meta
zaps forwarded to @sox (100%)

This is the climax of what sox has been cooking his way toward, release by release, over the last few months.

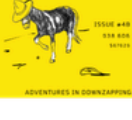
What was once the [preview](#) tab on posts and comments is now also a what-you-see-is-what-you-get editor. Before, to add links, headings, quotes, and styling, you had to be a markdown wizard. Now, you can use a toolbar and click buttons like most editors you're familiar with.

The important part of this, and where sox put a ton of energy, is that the markdown editing experience is preserved. When editing a post or comment, you can switch between markdown and wysiwyg modes and see the changes you make in one reflected in the other. The wysiwyg, what we're calling [compose](#) for lack of a better name, is an editable preview of the markdown, and [write](#) is a editable representation of the markdown "source code" for the work you do in [compose](#).

In many ways this is the beginning of our plans for the editor experience. It's the main way everyone makes SN what they want it to be and we want to maximize that. Before too long we'll add image resizing and, yes, a table editor, but we plan to go much further.

Sox is standing by for any bugs you find or suggestions you might have. Oh, and any complements of course.

Also, big shout to [@optimism](#) who has been helping us put the engineering back in software engineering.



bitcoin devs should be learning isogeny cryptography



8840 sats \ 6 comments \ [@conduition](#) 12 Mar bitcoin

Nowadays my focus is shifting towards research on cryptosystems that may someday replace Schnorr and ECDSA, without compromising too much on signature size and cryptographic flexibility. i was disappointed enough by lattices that I didn't even bother writing an article on them. But isogenies feel very different. There is structure, rules which can be manipulated. I think more people should be learning about isogenies as a long-term replacement for Schnorr.

Mind you, we still need a stopgap like hash-based signatures as a conservative fallback in case the assumptions of isogeny crypto are broken in the future.



and the most downzapped goes to

trump's war with iran is even more of a disaster than people realize



309 sats \ 49 comments \ [@Undisciplined](#) 7 Mar
Politics_And_Law -5000 sats

By Connor O'Keeffe

- The problem with this new campaign in Iran is not merely that it will likely have bad near-term consequences, but that it represents the American government doubling down on the imperial project that is causing our accelerating national crisis.